century history. And yet, the migrations that I have described in this chapter, of greater scale and enduring significance, are rarely featured in historical works on modern India. This has happened because of a curious oversight whereby all historical labour migration of the colonial period has been associated with the indentured system that ended in the early 20th century, and a failure to acknowledge internal and international migration within a common framework.[96]

The framework presented here, in contrast, reveals the Great Indian Migration Wave, which stands tall among the big migration episodes of global history. The trans-Atlantic slave trade lasted for centuries but was coercive in nature. The migration of Europeans in the age of mass migration was intense, but not coerced, and lasted for less than seven decades. The on-going migration linked with Chinese urbanization is more voluminous than the Indian one but is also of much more recent vintage. In India, migration for marriage affects virtually all adult women, but most often it is not directly related to work. Compared to these episodes, the Great Indian Migration Wave is arguably the largest and longest non-coerced migration stream for work in documented history.

The social composition of the wave has varied across space and time, but it appears to be over-represented by the relatively richer folk today. Likewise, the initial causes of the migration were complex and varied. They include factors like cyclones and famines, unequal and unjust land tenure systems, new trade routes, better transportation, wage differences, aspirations and an opportunity to escape social restrictions. But as a general pattern, regions with high population densities, often sustained by easy access to water and pre-existing migratory networks either through military service or global trade, were crucial factors in determining why some regions were more likely to participate in the wave than others.[97]

What explains the tremendous persistence of the Great Indian Migration Wave even in the 21st century? To answer this question, one has to understand why most Indians chose to return home after working outside for many years, sustaining long-lasting circulatory paths. This was because of factors arising in both the source and destination regions. In some